

Most important feature you never shop for

The modern device buyer obsesses over the glamorous things. Camera megapixels. AI tricks. OLED brightness. Battery life. Storage speed. But the single most important feature in your digital life is usually the one you think about only after disaster: backup. That is because, for the average reader, the real value of a phone or laptop is no longer the hardware itself. It is the life stored inside it — years of family photos, scanned IDs, tax papers, invoices, chats, passwords, college projects, office presentations, and the tiny fragments of daily life that quietly become irreplaceable. The numbers tell the story brutally. IDC projected the global data-sphere would hit 163 zettabytes by 2025, ten times the 16.1ZB generated in 2016. We are producing and storing more digital memory than ever before, and yet most people still protect it with little more than hope.

Hope, unfortunately, is not a backup strategy. CISA's ransomware guidance still makes the same core recommendation security professionals have repeated for years: maintain offline, encrypted backups of critical data, and regularly test the availability and integrity of those backups. That advice is not written only for banks and giant corporations. It applies just as much to the parent whose child's first videos live on one phone, the freelancer whose invoices and contracts sit on one laptop, or the student whose degree-era work is scattered across one Google account and a half-broken SSD. If your data matters, recovery matters.

And data loss is not some exotic event reserved for unlucky people on the internet. Backblaze's long-running backup survey found that 62% of computer owners had already lost data, while 20% had never backed up all the data on their systems. In a newer 2025 Western Digital survey, among respondents who do not back up their personal data, 36% said they simply do not think they need to, while 30% said they do not have enough storage. That combination — complacency plus clutter — is precisely how ordinary users sleepwalk into avoidable loss.

The risk is not only theft, failure or ransomware. It is also ordinary human behaviour. We delete the wrong folder. We reset the wrong phone. We assume "it's in the cloud somewhere." We mistake sync for backup. Apple's own support documentation makes clear that iCloud Photos keeps photos and videos stored in iCloud and up to date across devices, while Google says every Google Account's 15GB is shared across Photos, Gmail, and Drive. In other words, the cloud is helpful, but it is not infinite, and it is not automatically organised in your favour. A full account can stop backups. A synced deletion can spread a mistake. Convenience and resilience are not the same thing.

Even hardware, that supposedly dependable old workhorse, is no guarantee. Backblaze's 2025 drive report, based on more than 115 million drive days, recorded an annual hard-drive failure rate of 1.36%. That may sound low until you remember what a failed drive usually contains: not generic data, but your data. The family archive. The scanned documents. The half-finished novel. The wedding footage. The office records you were absolutely going to sort next weekend. The point is not that drives are bad. It is that every storage medium fails eventually, and backup exists to make that failure boring instead of devastating.

This is why this FastTrack matters. Not because backup is glamorous, but because it is foundational. Google now openly positions Google One as extra storage for photos, files, and device backups. Apple includes 5GB of iCloud storage with every device and sells higher iCloud+ tiers because it knows that modern users outgrow "free" quickly. Microsoft, likewise, now treats Windows Backup as a mainstream part of protecting files, apps, settings, and Wi-Fi information. The industry has already accepted that backup is not a niche habit. It is basic digital hygiene.

So consider this booklet your insurance against a very modern kind of heartbreak. Because the best backup is not the one you start after loss. It is the one you quietly set up before life gives you a reason to regret not doing it. **d**